

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SAR(I)TORIAL STATEMENT

Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman's sartorial choices have over the years become as much of a talking point as the financial statement she presents on Budget Day. So it was this time, as she announced the eighth budget of the Modi government. If this year's fiscal spotlight was 'Bihar-heavy', so was her attire—a cream handloom Madhubani sari adorned with fish motifs, a gift from Padma Shri awardee Dulari Devi. At a post-budget huddle, the FM regaled journalists with the tale behind the drape. Each sari takes over a month to paint, she said, and that there were two major Madhubani styles—Kachni, with its meticulous line-work, and Bharni, bursting with colours—both an upper-caste tradition. That last detail could prove one too many should Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi choose to take it up in his next tirade on caste discrimination.

Cinematic Splurge



Jaipur just hit a *filmi* jackpot—the IIFA Awards are rolling into town for their 25th edition, and Rajasthan's royal charm is about to get a Bollywood-sized bump up. The announcement in Mumbai was nothing short of a spectacle, with actors Shah Rukh Khan, Nora Fatehi and Kartik Aaryan sharing the stage with ex-royal and deputy CM **Diya Kumari**. But while the glitz is undeniable, the Rs 50 crore plus GST price tag has raised more than a few eyebrows. Never before has Rajasthan splurged this kind of money on a private event. The government insists it's a tourism masterstroke—free star-studded promos at heritage hotspots instead of expensive, ineffective ad campaigns. But what about the naysayers? They see it as a blockbuster budget with taxpayers footing the bill.

PADMA POLITICS

A monk gets a Padma Shri, and not a Ferrari, but was it still political pay-back? Bengal is abuzz with the question after **Swami Pradiptananda** aka Kartik Maharaj, bagged the honour on January 25. A known critic of CM Mamata Banerjee, the Beldanga Bharat Sevashram Sangha secretary shot to fame after his public spat with her. When Mamata accused the monk of BJP links before the 2024 election, he slapped her with a defamation notice—although now, with a smirk, he's thanking her for making him famous. In the game of politics, even monks can't resist some well-timed "prasad".



New Mascot



Iqra Choudhary, the young Samajwadi Party MP from Kairana, is making headlines, but not in home state Uttar Pradesh. It is instead in neighbouring Delhi, and again not for her party but for INDIA ally Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). The unexpected showstopper during the poll campaign, she even led a grand roadshow for ex-deputy CM Manish Sisodia. Insiders say AAP couldn't get enough of her—over a dozen candidates wanted her on stage. Sure, party chief Akhilesh Yadav was all smiles standing next to Kejriwal in a show of alliance but, behind the scenes, it was Iqra's roadshow that had people talking. With the Yadav clan keeping aits distance from erstwhile ally, the jailed Azam Khan, is Iqra quietly becoming the 'Muslim face' in the SP?

Nitish's Flip Side

Bihar CM Nitish Kumar's political tango with Jitan Ram Manjhi could well rival a Bollywood script. First, he anointed Manjhi CM in 2014, only to oust him in 2015. Fast forward to November 2023, and Nitish was allied with the RJD when he dismissed the Mahadalit leader as a man "with no sense" in the state assembly. But now it's election year in Bihar and Nitish has executed another flip. On February 2, he visited Manjhi's Patna home and was soon hugging the man he once called his "biggest mistake". Guess some mistakes don't look so big when election season is upon you.



ANI

Kaushik Deka with Sonal Khetarpal, Avaneesh Mishra, Amitabh Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Rohit Parihar